justice informed Parliament that 1,631 complaints about judicial corruption had been received between 2017 and 2021 and forwarded to the CJI or high court chief justices. Even basic transparency measures, such as judges declaring their assets publicly, have been inconsistent. As of March, there are 34 judges in the SC, including the CJI, and about 1,100 in India's 25 high courts. Out of these, only 98 judges have publicly disclosed their assets.

The Supreme Court's stance on protecting high court judges from Lokpal scrutiny reflects these deep-seated concerns about judicial independence. In February, the court stayed a Lokpal order asserting jurisdiction over sitting high court judges. This protective posture also reflects the apex court's view that an established mechanism for judicial accountability already exists through the inhouse procedure overseen by the CJI. While this internal system has been criticised for lacking transparency, the judiciary has consistently maintained that it provides an appropriate balance between accountability and independence.

THE SC'S STANCE ON PROTECTING HC JUDGES FROM LOKPAL SCRUTINY STEMS FROM ITS DEEP CONCERNS ABOUT JUDICIAL INDEPENDENCE

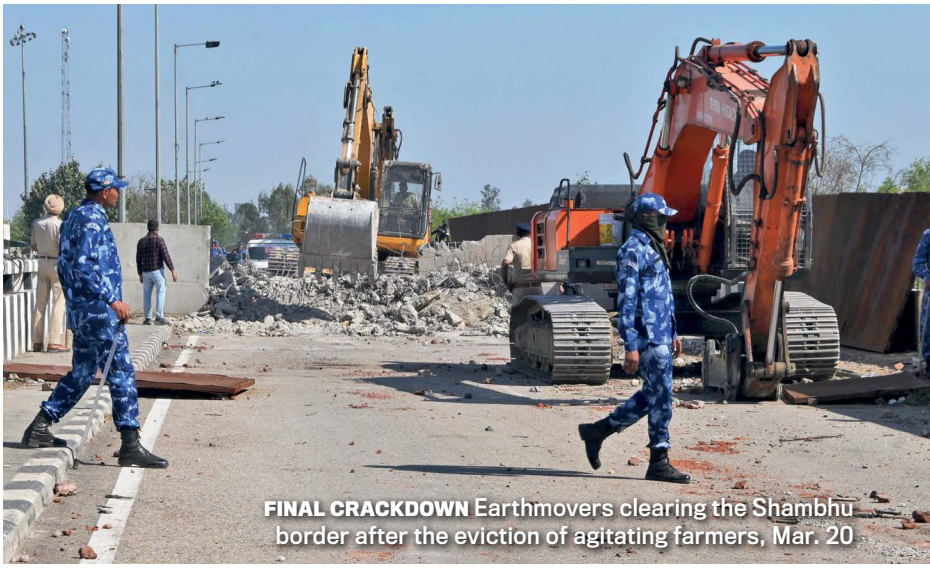
As the three-member committee conducts its inquiry into the Justice Varma case, the nation watches for signals about how seriously the judiciary takes allegations of corruption within its ranks. The outcome may well shape public perception of judicial integrity for years to come. ■

PUNJAB

Mann Shifts Gears

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

On March 20, Punjab Police launched a midnight crackdown on farm union protest sites at Shambhu (on the Patiala-Ambala highway) and Khanauri (Sangrur-Jind border), where demonstrations had been ongoing since February 2024. The operation was one of the most intense actions against farmer protests in the past decade. It was preceded by the detention of Kisan Mazdoor Morcha leader Sarvan Singh Pandher and Samyukta Kisan Morcha (Non Political) leader Jagjit Singh Dallewal just as they re-entered Punjab after meeting Union ministers Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Pralhad Joshi and Piyush Goyal in Chandigarh. The protest sites were forcibly cleared, with hundreds of farmers detained in the process. (Later, about 800 were released on March 24 with the promise to let another 450 go in the coming days.)



PTI

FINAL CRACKDOWN Earthmovers clearing the Shambhu border after the eviction of agitating farmers, Mar. 20

The move marks a significant shift in Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann's approach. Having built his career—first, as a satirist, and then, a politician—on siding with protesters, he is now positioning himself as a leader with a firm grip on governance. His administration has also cracked down on striking revenue officials and launched a bulldozer drive against drug traffickers. These aggressive measures appear to be part of a larger strategy to consolidate his authority within Punjab while simultaneously navigating the increasing dominance of the Aam Aadmi Party's central leadership in state affairs.

Just before the crackdown, Mann's agriculture minister, Gurmeet Singh Khudian, had been part of the consultations between farm leaders and